

Deny, deny, deny. Then approve to spy

9 divisions 2,063 written questions 243 distinct askers

Under-sixteens are to be banned from holding social media accounts on the Australian model. The list covers Snapchat, TikTok, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook and X. Regulations are promised by the end of the year. The ban comes into force in early 2027. The striking part is the about-turn. This spring the Commons voted an under-sixteen ban down by 307 to 173 in March, with more than a hundred Labour Members of Parliament abstaining. In December the Prime Minister called himself “personally opposed” to a blanket ban. Yet the statement uses the very discretionary power Members of Parliament granted instead, to bring the very ban they declined. The consequence runs well past teenagers. To keep under-sixteens out, platforms must age-check everyone, adults included. That points to an age-verified, identity-checked internet the Free Speech Union and privacy campaigners call surveillance by another name. It was the week’s defining story, and it came wrapped in a rebuke. The Deputy Speaker opened by recording the Speaker’s displeasure that the Prime Minister had unveiled it from Downing Street, not the House. Around it ran a tech-and-online-safety cluster, taking in disinformation, online hate speech and a cyber-security bill. The division bell rang nine times, most loudly to send the Railways Bill out of the Commons and up to the Lords.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Royal Albert Hall Bill [Lords], Revival		24–37
Cyber Security and Resilience (Ne...		162–246
Railways Bill Remaining Stages, A...		167–266
Cyber Security and Resilience (Ne...		151–258
Railways Bill Remaining Stages, A...		155–279
Railways Bill, Third Reading		278–149
Clean Air Zones Central Services (...)		262–86
Cyber Security and Resilience (Net...		77–255
Railways Bill Remaining Stages, N...		77–271

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Health		313
Housing		232
Transport		194
Defence		165
Home Office		129
Treasury		123
Education		122
Ministry of Justice		109
Environment		108
Business and Trade		97
Cabinet Office		86
Foreign Office		85
12 others		300

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

26 Drugs: Side Effects 12 Large Goods Vehicles: Electric Vehicles 11 Legal Aid Agency: Cybersecurity
10 Youth Mobility Scheme: India 10 Special Educational Needs 9 Voluntary Organisations: Finance 8 Housing: Construction
8 Pensions: Fraud 8 Lord Mandelson 6 HM Coastguard: Pay

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Mobile Phones: Children · Graham Stuart, Conservative
Whether the Department has assessed the most popular smartphone applications used by 8 to 14-year-olds after (a) 21:00 and (b) 23:00.

THE ANSWER Protecting children online is a priority for the Secretary of State and this government. That is why we published the ‘Growing up in the Online World’ consultation, accompanied by a National Conversation on 2 March 2026.

Department for Business and Trade: Lanyards · Mr Richard Holden, Conservative
How much the Department, its agencies and its public bodies has spent on lanyards since 4 July 2024, and what designs have been purchased.

THE ANSWER Since July 2024, DBT has spent £6,306.41 (including delivery charges) on a total of 4,530 lanyards through our print supplier and our stationery suppliers. UK Export Finance spent a further £2,774.28 on 1,570 lanyards for customer conferences and promotional events; in addition, 10 special lanyards were purchased for £28.50 in March 2025 to identify First Aiders among UKEF staff.

FEATURE

The ban they denied three times, and the age-check it puts on everyone

The week’s set-piece was a Government statement, not a bill. Under-sixteens are to be banned from holding social media accounts on the Australian model. The named platforms are Snapchat, TikTok, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook and X.